had less to do with technical capability and more to do with the lack of political will. The evidence suggests, therefore, that China's narrative about India lacking the capability to explode a nuclear device before the NPT was signed, is both specious and self-serving. The question is why did China construct this narrative?

From the very beginning, China had a clear vision about nuclear weapons. China's first-generation leadership led by Mao Zedong saw nuclear weapons as a counter-power to American bullying, and they built the bomb. Its second-generation leadership led by Deng Xiaoping leveraged the bomb as a means to demonstrate that China was a responsible member of the international community, by steering China first into the International Atomic Energy Agency in 1984 and then into the NPT in 1992. The subsequent generations of leaders, in the post-Cold War period, saw nuclear weapons as a guarantor of China's status as a true world power with no equal other than the United States, especially in the Indo–Pacific region. To maintain this image, it was essential for China to preserve strategic asymmetry both in terms of optics and in terms of ground realities with other aspirants, especially India which had tested a device in 1974. Until 1998, China could project the image of strategic asymmetry through two means: by claiming to be the only nuclear power in Asia because India and Pakistan had not yet declared themselves as nuclear weapons possessing states, and by manipulating the CTBT negotiations to try and lock India into permanent nuclear asymmetry with China. India's tests blew this policy out of the water. China, therefore, needed to construct a new narrative for preserving its strategic asymmetry in the twenty-first century.

China's objective even after the Indian nuclear tests in 1998 remained consistent—the preservation of strategic asymmetry vis-à-vis India and sustaining the perception that China was